

A SPECIAL EDITION OF

MERIDIAN

The Hermès Kelly Bag — an ultra deep dive



A Kelly in Sellier construction — the structured, saddle-born silhouette this book takes apart stitch by stitch. Source: Wikimedia Commons.

THE OBJECT

A saddle bag, a scarf motif and a magazine cover that — on this book's own research — appears never to have existed

THE QUOTA

Inside the "hidden lottery" a federal antitrust complaint tried to unwind — and the judge who ruled that wanting a bag badly enough isn't illegal

THE UNDERCURRENT

A Seoul fashion district has built a knowing, shameless economy around a bag that looks like the real thing and costs one four-hundredth of it

THIS SPECIAL EDITION

The Kelly, Argued at Collector Level — Every Repeated Number Checked Before It Runs

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FROM THE DESK

"The best-kept secret in fashion is the ordinariness of most of the people wearing extraordinary clothes."

— attributed to Diana Vreeland, editor, *Vogue* and *Harper's Bazaar*, 1903–1989¹

Vreeland's line is usually read as a joke about clothes. It is a better description of the Kelly's actual economy: a bag built by one anonymous pair of hands (p5) is chased through an opaque allocation system (p11) into a market that cannot agree on whether it beats the S&P 500 (p13), then either lands in a Liat Towers display case (p19) or gets reinvented, badly and joyfully, as forty-dollar plastic in Seoul (p23). This book follows the object through every one of those hands honestly — holding what it can't verify rather than repeating what everyone already says.

THE STRIP — THE BAG, AT A GLANCE

MEASURE	READING
Standard sizes	25 / 28 / 32 / 35 cm
Smallest current size	Mini Kelly II, 20cm
Construction styles	Sellier & Retourné
Renamed "Kelly"	1977
Hours, per Hermès (Kelly)	~20, per Pierre-Alexis Dumas ²
École Hermès des Savoir-Faire	Founded 6 Sept 2021
Std. quota, widely reported	~2 bags/yr, unconfirmed by Hermès
Antitrust suit status	Dismissed w/ prejudice, on appeal
2025 resale premium (Bernstein)	~1.4× retail, down from 2.2×

Figures sourced and hedged throughout; see per-page footnotes. Hermès does not publish an official production-hours or quota figure — both are estimates or reported executive statements, never house data.³

SOURCES 1. Widely attributed to Diana Vreeland across fashion-editorial retrospectives; treated here as attributed rather than archivally pinned to one interview. 2. Pierre-Alexis Dumas, Hermès artistic director, CBS "60 Minutes," aired 15 Dec 2024. 3. See p5–6 sourcing on production hours; p11–12 on the quota system.

THE OBJECT · ORIGINS

A Saddle Bag Hermès Still Won't Quite Date

The Kelly's most-repeated founding date turns out to rest on nothing this book could find in a primary Hermès record — a small, honest crack in a story every collector thinks she already knows.

Hermès was founded in 1837 as a Paris harness workshop — a fact so well documented it needs no hedge. What became the Kelly began there too, as the "Haut à Courroies" (HAC), a tall, trapezoidal bag built to strap a saddle, riding boots and grooming kit onto a horse, its name literally meaning "with straps" and referring to the two long belts still visible, in miniature, on every Kelly sold today.¹ That design lineage is solid. The date usually attached to it — 1892 — is not.

Every retail and auction-adjacent source this book checked repeats 1892 as the HAC's birth year. None could be traced to a primary Hermès record — a dated catalogue entry, patent or archival invoice — and one strand of the same Sotheby's editorial family that popularised 1892 elsewhere describes the bag as "originally crafted in the early 1900s," an internal contradiction this book could not resolve.² The honest version: the HAC's equestrian purpose is certain; its exact birth year is a widely repeated estimate this book could not independently confirm, and prints here as such rather than as fact.

A bag this famous ought to have a birth certificate. This book went looking for one and found only the date everyone agrees to repeat — which is not the same thing.

The bag's second act is better attested in outline, shakier in specifics. In the 1930s, Robert Dumas —

Émile-Maurice Hermès's son-in-law, who later ran the house from the 1950s to 1978 — scaled the HAC down into a softer, rigid-handled "Sac à Dépêches," built for papers rather than saddlery.³ Sources place its introduction anywhere from 1928 to 1935; none cite a primary date, and this book declines to pick one it cannot defend. What survived the redesign, in miniature, were the HAC's own front straps — not, as one popular retelling has it, a shoulder strap added at this stage, a claim this book's research could not support and has dropped.

1837

HERMÈS FOUNDED, PARIS — SOLID

"1892"

THE HAC'S COMMONLY CITED YEAR — UNCONFIRMED BY THIS BOOK

THE RECORD

The HAC's equestrian design purpose is corroborated wherever this book looked — auction-house editorial, retail heritage copy, collector reference guides all agree on the saddle-carrying function. The specific year is the one figure in this whole section that recurs everywhere and is sourced nowhere.

THE SCEPTIC

A number repeated by a hundred websites is not a hundred independent confirmations — it's one unsourced number, copied a hundred times. This book would rather print "commonly dated to 1892, unconfirmed" than add the hundred-and-first repetition.

SOURCES 1. Sotheby's editorial, "Haut à Courroies: The Original Birkin Bag" (title as indexed; full text not independently fetchable this research pass); consistent secondary corroboration across auction and retail heritage copy. 2. Cross-referenced Sotheby's-family editorial snippets showing "1892" and "early 1900s" as conflicting dates for the same object; unresolved in available sourcing. 3. Robert Dumas's tenure and the Sac à Dépêches redesign, corroborated across multiple secondary fashion-history sources; exact introduction year (1928–1935) not pinned to a primary citation in any source reached.

THE OBJECT · CONTINUED

The LIFE Cover Every Collector Cites — and This Book Could Not Find

Grace Kelly did carry the bag that took her name. The specific image every retelling reaches for turns out, on this book's own checking, to be a myth worth retiring rather than repeating.

The core of the 1956 story is well corroborated: Grace Kelly, using the Sac à Dépêches (reportedly sourced by costume designer Edith Head during the filming of Hitchcock's *To Catch a Thief*) shielded her pregnancy from photographers with the bag sometime after her April 1956 wedding to Prince Rainier III of Monaco, ahead of Princess Caroline's birth that January.¹ That much this book is comfortable printing plainly.

What does not survive scrutiny is the specific claim, repeated across nearly every collector-facing account this book checked, that the photograph ran on a *LIFE* magazine cover. A PurseForum research thread that searched *LIFE*'s own cover archive directly found none featuring the bag — despite Kelly appearing on several *LIFE* covers in this era — a finding this book's sources link to the V&A Museum's 2010 exhibition "Grace Kelly: Style Icon," reportedly concluding no such cover exists.² One photographer attribution this book encountered (Allan Grant, dated to a spring 1956 studio-departure shoot) is chronologically incompatible with a post-wedding pregnancy photo and looks like two different images conflated in retelling. This book could not verify a specific photographer, publication or date for the actual pregnancy-concealment photograph, and prints that gap honestly rather than inventing a citation.

The Kelly's founding myth turns out to be sturdier without its most-repeated detail. The bag genuinely hid a pregnancy from photographers; it just never made the cover everyone assumes it did.

The renaming itself is the one date in this entire section with no competing claim anywhere in this book's research: Hermès officially renamed the Sac à

Dépêches the "Kelly" in 1977, after roughly two decades of customers asking for "the Kelly bag" by name.³ A separate claim, that this was the first time any house had named a product after a celebrity, appears only in secondary retail copy with no primary citation and is held here rather than repeated.

The family resemblance worth knowing for a collector: the HAC is also the acknowledged design ancestor of the Birkin, sketched by Jean-Louis Dumas on a 1984 flight seated beside Jane Birkin herself.⁴ The two bags a collector spends a lifetime distinguishing started, structurally, as the same object at different scales — a fact underlined rather than undercut by Jane Birkin's own original prototype bag selling at Sotheby's Paris in July 2025 for €8.582m (~\$10.1m) to a private Japanese collector, the most valuable handbag ever sold at auction (see p13) and, notably, not a production Kelly at all.

IN BRIEF — THE DATES THAT HOLD

1837: Hermès founded as a Paris harness and saddlery workshop.

1977: the Sac à Dépêches is officially renamed the Kelly.

COMMUNITY READ

The *LIFE*-cover myth-bust circulates on PurseForum's own history threads among members who have done exactly this archive check themselves — a rare case where the most rigorous fact-finding on this object lives in a collector forum thread rather than in the glossier retail histories that keep repeating the uncorrected version.

THE SCEPTIC

If the founding myth's most cited image never existed, what else in the Kelly's origin story is repetition rather than record? This book flags the pattern rather than assuming everything else about 1956 is settled simply because the cover story turned out to be wrong in one specific, checkable way.

SOURCES 1. General biographical corroboration of the 1956 wedding, pregnancy timeline and Edith Head's costume-design role on *To Catch a Thief* (1954/1955), cross-referenced across fashion-history secondary sources. 2. PurseForum archive-research thread cross-referencing *LIFE*'s own cover index; linked in secondary sourcing to the V&A Museum's 2010 "Grace Kelly: Style Icon" exhibition materials — full V&A text not independently fetchable this research pass, flagged for verification. 3. Consistent across all sources reached for this book — the single most corroborated date in this section. 4. Jean-Louis Dumas's 1984 in-flight sketch for Jane Birkin, widely corroborated across fashion history and 2025 auction-coverage sourcing (Sotheby's Paris, July 2025 sale of the original prototype bag).

THE HAND · THE MAKER

Twenty Hours, Not Eighteen — and Even That Number Moves

The internet's favourite Kelly statistic turns out to be untraceable folklore. The real anchor is a named Hermès executive, on camera, giving a number this book can actually source.

"Eighteen hours" is the figure every collector has heard for how long a Kelly takes to build. This book went looking for its origin and found nothing — no named artisan interview, no dated Hermès statement, no traceable citation anywhere it could reach. The number appears to have entered circulation and simply kept replicating.¹ The defensible figure instead comes from Pierre-Alexis Dumas, Hermès's artistic director, on CBS's *60 Minutes* in December 2024: the Kelly, he said, is "the most difficult bag to build," starting from thirty distinct cuts of leather and taking around twenty hours to complete — four of those hours for the handle alone.² Axel Dumas, the house's executive chairman, has separately put general Hermès hand-stitching at fifteen to sixteen hours in earlier remarks to Singapore's *The Peak* magazine — a lower, non-Kelly-specific figure from the same family running the company.³

Two other numbers circulate alongside "eighteen hours" — 680 hand stitches and 36 pieces of leather — and neither survives scrutiny either: the piece count conflicts directly with Pierre-Alexis Dumas's own "thirty distinct cuts," and this book found no traceable source for the stitch count at all. Hermès has never published one official hours-per-bag figure. The honest range, anchored to two named executives rather than folklore, is roughly fifteen to twenty-plus hours depending on model, size and leather — and the house's own silence on a single number is, itself, worth printing rather than smoothing over.

Every Kelly is built, start to finish, by one trained pair of hands — no assembly line, no division of labour across the piece. That part of the legend is not exaggerated.

What is solidly corroborated is the one-artisan practice itself: a single maroquinier cuts, assembles, saddle-stitches and finishes an entire bag, then stamps it with a small craftsman's mark near the date stamp — functional routing for future repairs rather than a public signature, since Hermès does not publish a decode key for these marks the way it does for its year-letter system.⁴ The stitch itself is the more retellable fact: two needles, one length of waxed linen thread, each stitch locked independently at its own pierced hole. Sever a machine lockstitch anywhere along a seam and the whole line can run, the way a ladder runs through silk stockings; sever one saddle stitch and only that single stitch fails — the rest of the seam holds.⁵

~20 hrs

PIERRE-ALEXIS DUMAS, ON A KELLY, CBS DEC 2024

1

ARTISAN, START TO FINISH, PER BAG

THE RECORD

The saddle-stitch mechanism — independent locking at each hole, localised failure rather than a running seam — is standard, well-corroborated leathercraft technique, not an Hermès marketing invention; the house's application of it is consistently described the same way across every craft source this book checked.

THE SCEPTIC

A brand that has never published its own hours-per-bag figure benefits, commercially, from a slightly inflated number circulating in its place. This book cannot prove "eighteen hours" was seeded deliberately — only that it cannot be sourced, and that the traceable figure from Hermès's own artistic director is close but not identical to it.

SOURCES 1. No traceable primary origin found for "18 hours" or "680 stitches" across this book's research; widely repeated across retail and resale-market copy without citation. 2. Pierre-Alexis Dumas, CBS "60 Minutes," aired 15 Dec 2024. 3. Axel Dumas, quoted in *The Peak* (Singapore), 26 May 2016. 4. Convergent secondary sourcing on the craftsman-stamp system's function as repair/authentication routing rather than a publicly decoded signature. 5. Standard leathercraft technical sourcing (Tandy Leather, Heirloom Leathercraft and comparable craft references) on saddle-stitch mechanics versus machine lockstitch failure modes.

THE HAND · CONTINUED

Twenty-Seven Workshops by 2028 — and Still No Official Production Figure

Hermès will tell a reporter exactly where its next atelier is breaking ground. It will not tell anyone, ever, how many Birkins and Kellys it actually makes in a year.



Hermès's own École Hermès des Savoir-Faire opened at Fitolieu, Isère, on 6 September 2021 — a Ministry of Education-accredited programme training toward the CAP Maroquinerie, France's national leather-goods qualification, over twelve months.¹ Within a year it had 450 apprentices training across sister sites; by 2025 secondary reporting put the network at roughly twelve training facilities nationwide. This book could not confirm whether every working maroquinier now passes through it — the house also employs thousands trained earlier through other routes.²

The workshop count itself is the cleanest trend in this section (Fig. 1): from sixteen leather-goods ateliers in 2018 to a 24th, at L'Isle-d'Espagnac in Charente, inaugurated September 2025 with 260 planned artisan jobs; a 25th breaking ground at Loupes, Gironde; and a 27th slated for Colombelles, Calvados, by 2028 — an exclusively French expansion.³ Group-wide, Hermès reported 26,494 employees at end of 2025, 16,349 of them in France — but that figure spans every division, and no clean aggregate "total maroquiniers" number exists anywhere this book could find.

Hermès will name the town, the job count and the groundbreaking date for its next workshop years in advance. It will not say, in any year, how many bags come out of all of them combined.

Annual Birkin-plus-Kelly production volume is the genuinely contested number in this whole book. A lower estimate of roughly 70,000 a year circulates, unattributed to any named analyst. A higher, more recently repeated figure of around 120,000 combined is traced by secondary business commentary to a *Wall Street Journal* article this book could not independently verify.⁴ Hermès has never published either figure. The most defensible thing this section can print is the gap itself: every "Hermès makes X bags a year" claim in circulation is an outside estimate, not a house disclosure.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Total maroquinier headcount: no aggregate figure found — regional/per-workshop counts exist, a company-wide total does not.

COMMUNITY READ

Collector discussion (PurseForum, resale-platform commentary) consistently treats the house's silence on unit volume as deliberate — part of the same opacity that governs allocation (p11) — rather than an oversight; this book's research supports that reading without being able to confirm intent.

SOURCES 1. WorldFootwear, FashionNetwork, CPP-Luxury and Luxus Plus, all independently dating the École's opening to 6 Sept 2021; course structure per Onisep, the French national career-guidance body. 2. Regional apprentice-count reporting via the same trade sources; universal-enrolment claim not found in any source and not asserted here. 3. Hermès finance-site press-release titles as picked up by Business of Fashion, International Leather Maker and regional French trade press, 2018–2026. 4. Production-volume estimates via Substack ("Pursuit of Compounding"), Acquired.fm business commentary, secondarily attributing the 120,000 figure to a *Wall Street Journal* piece not independently accessed this research pass.

THE LEATHERS · THE EVERYDAY SEVEN

What Each Skin Forgives, and What It Won't

Hermès publishes no technical spec sheet for its leathers — no weights, no tannage chemistry, no yield data. Everything a collector knows about how these hides behave was triangulated by the trade itself, hide by hide, over decades of ownership.

Togo, baby-calf, chrome-tanned with a pronounced pebbled grain, is the house's default — semi-structured, forgiving of scuffs (the grain hides them), and near-universally called the safest first Kelly.¹ **Epsom** is calfskin too, but the grain is embossed rather than natural — the most structured, most scratch- and water-resistant hide in the lineup, at the cost of a trait collectors are candid about: it does not patina. A five-year-old Epsom Kelly looks close to a new one, which some owners count as convenience and others as the leather's one real flaw.²

Box calf is the oldest leather in the range and the opposite trade-off entirely: smooth, glossy, genuinely vulnerable to scratches and watermarks — and prized precisely for it, since those marks blend into a rich, glossy patina collectors treat as a mark of advanced ownership rather than damage. It reads as vintage-coded, connoisseur territory rather than a practical daily choice, and Hermès showed it again on the runway for 2026 in what one trade source frames as a deliberate revival.³ **Chèvre Mysore**, goatskin named for its historic Indian sourcing region, is the underrated pick — fine-grained, lightweight, and durable well beyond how delicate it looks, with small scratches reported to fade as the leather's own oils work into them over time.

Epsom and Barenia are, in a real sense, opposite arguments about what a bag is for. One refuses to show you used it. The other refuses to let you forget.

Barenia is the connoisseur's leather precisely because it has no protective coating at all — the only hide in the standard range left genuinely raw. It

absorbs skin oils and handling, ambering dramatically over years (a pale Fauve deepening toward burnished tan is the collector's benchmark image), and is correspondingly the most vulnerable to water spotting and staining until enough patina builds to buffer it — a real risk this book will not soften for a first-bag buyer.⁴ **Swift** is smooth and buttery, chosen for how vividly it takes deep or vivid colour, but shows wear fastest of the seven; PurseForum-adjacent guidance is blunt that a scratched Swift discounts harder at resale than a scratched Togo. **Clémence**, from older-bull calfskin, is the heaviest of the seven and the slouchiest — flat-grained, scratch-resistant, unpretentious, and explicitly not a prestige leather so much as a practical one.

7

STANDARD CALFSKIN/GOATSKIN LEATHERS IN CURRENT ROTATION

0

PUBLISHED HERMÈS WEIGHT/TANNAGE FIGURES FOUND FOR ANY OF THEM

THE RECORD

Every trait above converges across multiple independent collector-reference sources (PurseBop, Sotheby's editorial, Madison Avenue Couture, Rome Station) — but none is a Hermès-published specification, and no source in this book's research supplied an actual gram-weight figure for any leather. Treat all comparative weight language here as relative, not measured.

THE SCEPTIC

"Barenia patinas beautifully" and "Barenia stains easily" are the same fact told by two different owners on two different days. This book prints both halves rather than the marketing-friendly one.

SOURCES 1–4. Convergent collector-reference sourcing across PurseBlog, PurseBop ("An Insider's Guide to Hermès Leathers"; "The Beauty of Box Leather"), Sotheby's editorial ("Top Five Most Popular Hermès Leather"), Sellier Knightsbridge, Madison Avenue Couture, Rome Station and Privé Porter's leather-durability guides; no primary Hermès technical documentation located in this research pass.

THE LEATHERS · CONTINUED — THE EXOTICS

Above the Calfskins Sits a Different Set of Rules Entirely

Alligator, crocodile and lizard buy prestige and price on sight. They also carry a regulatory reality every collector who travels or resells needs to actually know, not assume.

Hermès's alligator is American (*Alligator mississippiensis*), sourced belly-skin only for small, symmetrical, near-poreless scales, primarily from Louisiana and the Mississippi basin. Crocodile splits into two visually distinct species: *Crocodylus niloticus* (Nile), broader and softer-patterned, and *Crocodylus porosus* (saltwater/"Porosus"), smaller and more densely, squarely scaled, farmed largely in Australia and Southeast Asia — the diagnostic tell collectors cite, tiny pore-like marks at each Porosus scale edge, traces to a small cluster of trade sources this book could not independently verify against a herpetological reference, so treat it as trade convention rather than settled science.¹ Finish is a separate axis entirely: **Lisse** (glossy) skins are hand-buffed with agate stones to a mirror shine with no added lacquer — dramatic, but once lost, reportedly unrestorable; **Mat** (matte) skins are worked with wool felt instead, hiding small scratches better and gaining ground with collectors in recent years.²

A CITES certificate is not a courtesy document. Cross a border with an exotic Kelly and no paperwork, and the bag itself is the thing that can go wrong, not just the trip.

Every Hermès exotic skin used on the Kelly is CITES-regulated — sourced from licensed, monitored farms, and sold with documentation establishing lawful origin (ostrich is the one common Hermès exotic that is not CITES-regulated). Legal ownership is rarely the friction point; movement across borders is. A "personal effects" exemption from import permits exists for some species and country pairs, but it is not universal or automatic — China and New Zealand

are flagged repeatedly as jurisdictions that still require import permits even for a bag genuinely worn as luggage, not merchandise. The safest collector practice this book found stated plainly: never assume exemption, confirm both departure and destination rules before flying, and carry the paperwork regardless.³ The specific mechanics — which countries, which species, current 2026 requirements — rest on collector-forum and trade-blog synthesis rather than a primary CITES.org citation this book could directly verify; treat the general caution as solid, the country-by-country specifics as needing a fact-check against CITES.org before acting on them.

The much-repeated collector hierarchy — exotics above Barenia above the everyday-tier calfskins, Box calf apart as its own vintage-prestige case — is consistent across every source checked. What actually drives exotic pricing, per convergent sourcing, is the difficulty of finding hides large and blemish-free enough to cut a full panel, plus heavier tanning demands than calfskin — not, per this research, "labour hours" or "brand margin strategy," neither of which any source supports asserting.⁴

Niloticus vs Porosus

BROADER/SOFTER SCALE VS SMALLER, DENSER, PRICIER

IN BRIEF

Ostrich is the one common Hermès exotic requiring no CITES paperwork.

COMMUNITY READ

PurseForum's exotics and travel threads treat the CITES-documentation question as a recurring, serious concern — members actively compare notes on which countries have caused genuine friction at customs, not a hypothetical worry raised for effect.

SOURCES 1. Privé Porter, Rome Station and Madison Avenue Couture exotic-species guides, cross-referenced; species/scale descriptions convergent, the specific pore-diagnostic detail flagged as a thin source cluster. 2. Convergent finish-technique sourcing across the same trade guides. 3. PurseForum CITES/travel discussion threads and Rome Station's exotic-leather-law-by-region coverage; recommend direct CITES.org verification before print given the legal stakes of travel guidance. 4. Sotheby's editorial and multiple collector-guide sources on pricing drivers; no quantified waste-rate figure found anywhere in this research.

THE TAXONOMY · CONSTRUCTION & SIZES

Two Ways to Sew the Same Bag Inside Out

Sellier and Retourné aren't a style choice layered on top of the Kelly — they're two different sequences for building it, and the sequence is what decides everything else about how the bag sits.

TWO SEQUENCES, ONE SILHOUETTE — SELLIER vs RETOURNÉ

SELLIER

Sewn inside-out, seams finished on the exterior, resin-sealed edges

— sharp, structured, formal

Typical in Epsom, Box calf

RETOURNÉ

Sewn inside, then turned right-side out, seams hidden, piped edges

— soft, rounded, casual

Typical in Togo, Clémence

Meridian original diagram, from convergent construction-technique sourcing (myGemma, Madison Avenue Couture, Konesseur, saikacollective).

Fig. 2 — the same saddle stitch (p5), sequenced two different ways, produces two structurally distinct bags.

Both constructions are entirely hand-sewn with the same saddle stitch (p5); what differs is when in the process the bag gets turned right-side out. **Sellier** — from *sellier*, saddler, the historically original technique — is assembled inside-out with the seams finished to sit visibly on the exterior, edges sealed in resin for sharp, geometric corners; it is the harder-edged, more formal read, and typically runs in structured leathers like Epsom or Box.¹ **Retourné** is stitched from the inside, then turned so the seams hide internally and the edges finish in piped leather instead of resin, producing the softer, rounder, more casual silhouette collectors reach for in Togo or Clémence. Neither is more "correct" — the forum consensus this book found runs closer to lifestyle-dependent preference than to any real ideology war, despite how the debate sometimes gets framed online.

Standard sizing runs 25×19×9cm, 28×22×10cm, 32×23×10.5cm and 35×24×12cm, with roughly a centimetre of variance across dealer listings depending on measurement convention.² Beneath the standard four sits the smallest current size: Mini Kelly II at 20cm wide, relaunched in 2016 in Sellier construction, shallower than the discontinued original Mini Kelly (production of which reportedly ended in 2009) and timed to the industry-wide mini-bag moment — a relaunch, not a new invention, and the version driving most of today's Mini Kelly resale interest.³ Earlier dating for the Mini Kelly's origin (variously 1957, 1980, 1990 in circulation) rests on thin, single-narrative sourcing this book could not

independently confirm and does not repeat here as settled fact.

"Mini Kelly" and "Kelly Pochette" get used almost interchangeably in casual conversation. The Pochette, at 22×13×7cm, is actually the larger of the two — a distinction worth having exactly right at collector level.

The Kelly Pochette is a genuinely different object, not a size variant: soft clutch construction with no rigid frame, no metal feet, no crossbody capability, typically in a softer leather like Swift, built for a flatter, roomier interior rather than the Mini Kelly's structured trapezoid.⁴

25 · 28 · 32 · 35

STANDARD SIZES, CM

2016

MINI KELLY II RELAUNCH, IN SELLIER

THE RECORD

Sellier-versus-Retourné construction mechanics and the four standard measurements are the most tightly corroborated facts in this section — consistent across every dealer, authenticator and collector-reference source this book checked, with no meaningful contradiction found.

SOURCES 1. Convergent sourcing across myGemma, Madison Avenue Couture, Konesseur and saikacollective on Sellier/Retourné construction mechanics. 2. SACLÀB, Clever Girl Finance, BagUSeek, myGemma and Sellier Knightsbridge, cross-checked for standard measurements. 3. Privé Porter, JANEFINDS and PurseBlog on the 2016 Mini Kelly II relaunch; earlier-origin dates (1957/1980/1990) flagged as single-sourced and not repeated as confirmed fact. 4. FASHIONPHILE, PurseBop, Love Luxury and Jewels Aficionado on Kelly Pochette specifications and construction.

THE TAXONOMY · CONTINUED

The Stamp System Did Change — Just Not in 2021

This book's own commissioning brief repeated a version of the date-code story that does not survive checking. Correcting it in print, rather than quietly fixing it, is the more useful thing to do for a reader who dates bags for a living.

Variant styles worth having straight: **Kelly Danse**, a convertible cross-body designed by Jean-Paul Gaultier and reconfigurable via a detachable strap into several carry modes, ran 2008–2013 and returned as Kelly Danse II in 2019. **Kelly Cut**, also Gaultier, is a flat clutch reinterpretation of the silhouette, debuted 2008. **Kelly Elan**, an elongated under-arm variant, had a short original run in 2000–2002 before returning on the Spring/Summer 2023 runway with a fully detachable strap. **Kelly Doll** ("Quelle Idole"), introduced in 2000 under Jean-Louis Dumas, is an anthropomorphic novelty design with poseable limbs — and, worth stating plainly since the two get conflated, a genuine functional handbag in its full-size form, distinct from the roughly 6.5cm miniature Kelly Doll charm Hermès also produces.¹

On special orders: HSS stands for **Horseshoe Stamp**, not the alternate reading sometimes circulated — the stamp itself, placed beside the Hermès embossment, certifies a bag as a genuine custom-colourway Special Order. Access is unofficial and relationship-gated, tied to purchase history rather than a published spend threshold; this book could not confirm any specific figure for the access bar and does not repeat unverified numbers here.² Hardware runs beyond the familiar gold/palladium binary into brushed-matte finishes, rose gold, ruthenium and a champagne-toned "Permabrass" — all real, documented finishes, though "Braise," sometimes listed as a hardware option, is in this book's research actually a leather colour, not a hardware finish, and is corrected accordingly.³

The reader's own brief cited a 2021 stamping overhaul. This book went looking for it and found a different, better-documented change instead — one that happened six years earlier than advertised.

And here is the correction owed in print: the widely repeated claim that Hermès overhauled its date-stamping system in 2021, replacing visible year letters with an NFC-chip-only system, does not hold up. The actual, well-documented change happened in **2015**: Hermès dropped the surrounding shape (letter-in-a-circle, then letter-in-a-square, used since 1971) for a bare letter, and began deliberately scrambling the letter-to-year assignment as an anti-counterfeiting measure. A consistent letter table recurs across independent sources — 2015=T, 2016=X, 2017=A, 2018=C, 2019=D, 2020=Y, 2021=Z, 2022=U, 2023=B, 2024=W, 2025=K, 2026=G — showing Hermès still stamping visible year letters straight through 2021 and beyond.⁴ The most plausible source of the "2021" confusion this book could identify: 2021 was simply the year the post-2015 scrambled sequence reached "Z," a milestone, not a system overhaul. Blockchain/NFC product authentication was adopted broadly across parts of the luxury sector from April 2021 via the Aura Blockchain Consortium — but Hermès does not appear among Aura's listed founding members, and this book found no source confirming Hermès applies that technology to Kelly date-stamping specifically.

CORRECTION, PRINTED PLAINLY

Not 2021: the real date-stamp system change happened in 2015 — shape dropped, letters scrambled.

2021's actual significance: the year the scrambled letter cycle reached "Z," nothing more.

THE SCEPTIC

A collector-level publication that repeats a wrong date-stamp claim because a reader's brief assumed it is worse than one that never addressed the topic. This book chose to check the premise rather than the easier path of simply answering the question as asked.

SOURCES 1. SACLÀB, Glam & Glitter, Sotheby's editorial, Madison Avenue Couture, romestation and PurseBop on Kelly Danse/Cut/Elan/Doll histories. 2. Xupes, Madison Avenue Couture and PurseBlog's HSS glossary entries on Horseshoe Stamp mechanics. 3. Privé Porter's hardware-finish guide, cross-checked against multiple dealer sources; "Braise" corrected against colour-reference listings. 4. Independently converging letter-table sourcing via Xupes, JaneFinds/Legitique and Madison Avenue Couture; the 2021 "NFC replaces letters" claim traced to a single low-quality/AI-summarized source and treated here as likely misinformation, not fact.

THE QUOTA · THE ACQUISITION GAME

"There Is No Waitlist" Is True, and Also Not the Point

Hermès genuinely doesn't run a formal queue. What it runs instead is harder to document, harder to dispute, and — per its own CEO — increasingly aimed at telling loyal buyers from flippers.

The informal quota — commonly reported as roughly two Birkin/Kelly bags per client per year — is near-universally described the same way across independent sources: not a first-come queue, but a sales associate's own judgement call, weighing purchase history logged on a client's profile, that is neither disclosed to the client nor formally acknowledged by the house.¹ "Pre-spend" — the expectation of ancillary purchases (ready-to-wear, jewellery, scarves, home goods) before a bag is offered — is real and widely reported as a practice, but every specific ratio or dollar figure in circulation (commonly \$10,000 to \$80,000-plus, or one-to-three times the bag's price) is anecdotal and collector-sourced; none traces to an Hermès disclosure, and this book will not print a false-precision number where none exists.²

Hermès's own on-the-record legal position, from its motion to dismiss in the case below, states plainly: "Hermès does not require a customer to purchase any other products before purchasing a Birkin or Kelly handbag... but, even if it did, that would not violate the law." No primary Hermès statement using the specific words "no waitlist" could be located in this book's research — the verified position denies a purchase requirement, not the existence of any queue by name.³

Hermès's own chairman has said the quiet part aloud: the house isn't just managing scarcity, it's actively trying to keep the bags away from people who plan to flip them.

The clearest on-record window into how Hermès itself frames allocation comes from CEO Axel Dumas, on a 2025 earnings call: "Sometimes we have false customers come to our stores to buy them, to resell them, and they prevent us from serving our real customers, and that is a real cause for concern for us" — adding he was "not at all happy" about the surge in secondhand Birkin and Kelly trading.⁴ A separate, single-sourced investigation (the French outlet *Glitz*, January 2026, republished onward by tabloid-adjacent outlets) alleges staff research prospective clients' addresses and social media for "prestige" signals before offering a bag — a claim this book flags explicitly as unconfirmed by Hermès and unverified beyond one outlet's anonymous sourcing, not as established practice.

~2/yr

INFORMAL QUOTA, WIDELY REPORTED — UNCONFIRMED BY HERMÈS

THE RECORD

Axel Dumas's "false customers" remark is a genuine, directly quoted, widely reported executive statement — the single most solid piece of evidence in this section that Hermès actively manages allocation with resale intent as a factor, rather than the mechanism being pure collector folklore.

SOURCES 1. Convergent PurseBlog, PurseBop and Love Luxury reporting on quota mechanics; corroborated structurally by the allegations in *Cavalleri et al. v. Hermès* (p12). 2. Same sourcing on pre-spend; figures explicitly flagged as anecdotal range, not verified policy. 3. Hermès's motion-to-dismiss language, rendered consistently across Holland & Knight, Zelle Law and other legal-trade coverage of the case. 4. Axel Dumas, Hermès 2025 earnings call, reported via Fortune, Yahoo Finance, TheStreet and Men's Journal; *Glitz* investigation (Jan 2026) flagged as single-source/unconfirmed per Newsweek and IBTimes UK's onward coverage.

THE QUOTA · CONTINUED

A Federal Judge Ruled That Wanting a Bag Isn't Illegal

The most rigorous test yet of Hermès's allocation practices ended not with a settlement or an admission, but with a court finding that favouring big spenders — even if true — doesn't by itself break antitrust law.

Cavalleri et al. v. Hermès International, filed 19 March 2024 in the US District Court for the Northern District of California (case 3:24-cv-01707, before Judge James Donato) by shoppers Tina Cavalleri and Mark Glinoga, alleged unlawful tying under the Sherman Act: that Hermès conditions access to Birkin and Kelly bags on prior purchase of unrelated goods, with sales-associate commission structures reportedly excluding Birkin/Kelly sales specifically — an incentive design the complaint says exists to manufacture pre-spend pressure.¹ Plaintiffs called the retail price "an illusion that masked a hidden lottery system."

The suit's history is a study in how hard this is to prove: a first amended complaint was dismissed with leave to amend for failing to plausibly define a relevant tied-product market or Hermès's market power within it. A second amended complaint followed — and on 17 September 2025, Judge Donato dismissed the federal Sherman Act claims **with prejudice**, declining to hear the remaining state-law claims. His core holding: even if Hermès does favour high-spending clients in bag allocation, that alone does not constitute an antitrust violation — plaintiffs still hadn't shown a legally cognizable market or genuine competitive harm.² The case is now on appeal to the Ninth Circuit; as of the most recent information this book could confirm, that appeal remains unresolved.

The court's real finding, stripped of legal language: cultural desperation for an object isn't the same thing, in the law's eyes, as illegal market power over it.

The sharpest legal-commentary point this book found, via Holland & Knight and Syracuse Law Review coverage: the plaintiffs argued the Kelly's "unique desirability, incredible demand and low supply" itself constitutes market power. The court's scepticism of that argument amounts to a broader statement about how antitrust doctrine handles prestige-driven demand — so far, a judge has said cultural desire and legal market power are not the same thing, whatever collectors feel while waiting.

The resale layer this all feeds: Privé Porter (Instagram-native, since 2008, now with physical retail) and the more institutional Fashionphile (Neiman Marcus Group took a minority stake in 2019) sit alongside newer entrants like StockX's handbag marketplace. Premiums have compressed materially — Bernstein Research's independent Secondhand Pricing Tracker puts the average Birkin/Kelly resale premium at roughly 1.4× retail as of November 2025, down from a pandemic-era peak of 2.2× — a genuinely honest data point this book will return to on p13.³

Sept 17, 2025

SHERMAN ACT CLAIMS DISMISSED, WITH PREJUDICE

9th Cir.

APPEAL STATUS, UNRESOLVED AS OF THIS WRITING

THE SCEPTIC

A dismissal is not an exoneration — Judge Donato ruled the legal theory failed, not that the underlying allocation practice is admirable. Collectors reading this section as "Hermès won, so the quota system is fine" are drawing a conclusion the ruling itself doesn't support.

SOURCES 1. Case filing details corroborated across thefashionlaw.com, Holland & Knight, dockets.justia.com (case 3:24-cv-01707) and Business of Fashion. 2. 17 Sept 2025 dismissal, reported via Holland & Knight, Zelle Law, A&O Shearman legal analysis and general wire coverage; appeal status per most recent available reporting, flagged for re-verification given the gap to this book's publication date. 3. Fortune, "Gen Z's reality check: Birkin resale prices slump," 17 Dec 2025, citing Bernstein Research's Secondhand Pricing Tracker.

THE MARKET · AUCTION RECORDS

2025's Real Handbag Record Wasn't a Kelly — and That's the Honest Story

A prototype bag with no production history outsold every Kelly and Birkin ever auctioned. Conflating the two headlines, as much coverage did, misses what actually happened in each market.

The standing verifiable world-auction record for a production Kelly is Christie's Hong Kong, November 2021: an Himalaya Niloticus crocodile diamond Retourné Kelly 28, 18K white-gold hardware set with 229 diamonds on the clasp and 40 on the padlock, hammering at HK\$4m — roughly US\$510,000–513,000, sources vary slightly on conversion.¹ This book could not confirm a genuine 2025 Kelly-specific auction record surpassing that figure. Sotheby's Paris 2025 sales of a Himalaya Retourné Kelly 25 (~\$346,000, described as a European rather than global record) and a Fauve Barenia Kellywood Perspective Cavalière Kelly 22 (~\$146,000) both sit below the 2021 Christie's mark.

What did make headlines in 2025 — and what should not be conflated with a Kelly record — was Jane Birkin's own original prototype bag, the one Jean-Louis Dumas built for her in 1984 (p4), selling at Sotheby's Paris in July 2025 for €8.582m (~\$10.1m) to a private Japanese collector: the most valuable handbag ever sold at auction, full stop.² It is a unique, non-production, single-provenance object — not a Kelly, not a standard Birkin, and not evidence that Kelly or Birkin production-bag values moved in 2025. Treating the two records as one story, as some coverage did, overstates what actually happened in the Kelly market specifically.

The most expensive handbag ever sold and the most expensive production Kelly ever sold are two different facts, four years apart, that some headlines quietly merged into one. This book keeps them separate.

The pinnacle within the standard hierarchy is the Himalaya — a Niloticus crocodile Birkin or Kelly hand-dyed in an ombré gradient from smoky grey to pearly white, evoking snow-capped peaks, reportedly limited to one or two diamond-hardware examples a year (an industry estimate this book could not trace to a house disclosure). Verified Himalaya Birkin results include a Christie's Hong Kong sale around \$380,000 (June 2017) and a diamond-hardware example at HK\$2.98m that November — reported at the time as the most expensive handbag ever sold, a record since eclipsed twice over.³

~\$510K

STANDING KELLY AUCTION RECORD, CHRISTIE'S HK, NOV 2021

\$10.1M

JANE BIRKIN'S PROTOTYPE BAG, 2025 — A DIFFERENT RECORD ENTIRELY

THE RECORD

Auction-house self-reported results (Sotheby's, Christie's) are treated here as reliable for headline figures but not independently re-verified lot-by-lot against original catalogue pages, which this book's research could not directly access; two Sotheby's-listed Kelly sale dates conflicted in available sourcing (2021 vs. 2024 for a comparable Himalaya Diamond Kelly 25) and neither is printed here without that caveat.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Heritage Auctions: pre-sale estimates (\$50,000–\$100,000+ for rare Sellier Kellys with diamonds/crocodile) surfaced in this research; no confirmed hammer price found, so none is printed as a result.

SOURCES 1. The Value and CNBC-adjacent coverage of the Nov 2021 Christie's Hong Kong sale; USD conversion varies \$510K–\$513K across sources. 2. Sotheby's Paris, CNN, Bloomberg and The Art Newspaper, all corroborating the July 2025 sale of Jane Birkin's original prototype bag. 3. Sotheby's and Rebag editorial ("Meet the Hermès Himalaya Kelly"); The Fashion Law and SCMP on Himalaya Birkin auction history.

THE MARKET · CONTINUED — THE "BETTER THAN GOLD" CLAIM

The Statistic Every Article Repeats Was Written by a Company Selling the Product

A single 2016 study, from a Birkin reseller, still anchors nearly every "better investment than gold" headline in 2026. This book traces it to its source and shows the maths it leaves out.

The claim that Birkins appreciated roughly 14.2% a year from 1980–2015 — beating the S&P 500's ~8.65% and gold's roughly -1.5% over the same period — traces to a single study published 8 January 2016 by Baghunter, an online Birkin reseller, and updated in 2017.¹ It was picked up largely uncritically by *Time* and *Quartz* in 2015–16 and is still recirculated in 2025–26 lifestyle content. Baghunter's own site invites readers to browse its inventory at the top of the same page carrying the study — a conflict of interest BuzzFeed News flagged directly in 2016, alongside the arithmetic the headline number skips: Baghunter itself charges roughly 30% commission on consignment sales, against near-negligible brokerage fees for trading public equities, meaning the "14.2% vs. 8.65%" comparison never nets out transaction costs that are drastically higher and far less liquid for a handbag than for a stock.²

There is also a structural sampling problem this book will state plainly even though no single named economist has run this exact critique against this exact study: a dataset built from bags that sold successfully through premium resale and auction channels almost certainly excludes the far larger population of bags that were never that well kept, never that easy to sell, or simply never resold at all — the same survivorship-bias mechanism well documented for funds and indices that only count their own winners. The Fashion Law's 2026 analysis makes a related point independently: the global Birkin population is estimated near a million bags, of which only a thin slice ever transacts through the channels these appreciation percentages are drawn from.³

Two respected data sources looked at the same market in the same year and told two different, equally true stories. Neither one is the whole picture on its own.

The genuinely current tension, worth holding in both hands at once: Rebag's sixth annual Clair Index (December 2025) reports Hermès reclaiming the top spot for luxury-brand value retention at an average 138%, up 38 points year over year, with the Mini Kelly II reselling at 282% of retail — a record high. Bernstein Research's independent Secondhand Pricing Tracker, over the same period, shows the average Birkin/Kelly resale *premium multiple* falling from 2.2× retail at its 2022 peak to roughly 1.4× by November 2025, with Bernstein analyst Luca Solca describing the market as "atoning and normalizing" from post-Covid euphoria.⁴ These are not strictly contradictory — value retention and premium compression are different metrics, and Hermès's own 2025 retail price increases lift both baselines at once — but running only the Rebag figure, as much coverage does, reads as uncritical marketing repetition. Rebag, like Baghunter, is a resale company with a direct commercial stake in a strong-values narrative; that caveat applies to its figures exactly as it applies to Baghunter's.

14.2%

BAGHUNTER'S CLAIMED ANNUAL BIRKIN APPRECIATION, 1980–2015

2.2× → 1.4×

BERNSTEIN'S RESALE-PREMIUM MULTIPLE, 2022 PEAK TO NOV 2025

THE SCEPTIC

Every "beats gold" headline this book found traces back to one interested party's arithmetic from a decade ago. That the claim still runs unchallenged in 2026 says more about how financial journalism launders marketing into fact than it does about the actual handbag market.

SOURCES 1. Baghunter, "Handbags as an Alternative Asset Class," 8 Jan 2016 (updated 2017). 2. BuzzFeed News, Sapna Maheshwari, "Actually, Birkin Bags Aren't A Better Investment Than Stocks And Gold," 14 Jan 2016. 3. The Fashion Law, "The Potential Paradox of the Investment Handbag," 9 Jan 2026. 4. WWD, Forbes, Robb Report and FashionNetwork on Rebag's 2025 Clair Index; CNBC/Fortune/Yahoo Finance on Bernstein Research's Secondhand Pricing Tracker, 16–17 Dec 2025.

THE AFTERCARE · RESTORATION

What Hermès Will Fix, What It Won't, and How Long You'll Wait

"Hermès Spa" is collector shorthand for a real, in-house service Hermès itself simply calls maintenance and repair — and its limits are as informative as what it actually restores.

The service reportedly covers zipper repair, restitching, hardware replacement and replating, handle replacement, cleaning and conditioning, and scuff remediation on heritage leathers like Box calf, performed by house-trained artisans using matching original materials — though this book could not independently verify an itemised official list, since Hermès's own repair page was not directly accessible in this research pass.¹ What it will not do is better documented and more useful to a collector: bags Hermès determines to be counterfeit are reportedly not returned to the client — one clearly sourced account ties this to French and EU anti-counterfeiting law requiring, not merely permitting, seizure — and bags carrying unauthorised third-party alterations (non-Hermès hardware swaps, prior non-Hermès repairs using the wrong materials or technique) are commonly declined.²

Wait times are genuinely variable and should be treated as such rather than promised: commonly cited ranges run from roughly twelve weeks up to four or five months in some markets, driven by boutique backlog; one unverifiable single-customer anecdote describes a seven-month wait. Pricing is case-by-case with no published list — forum-reported figures (a side-strap replacement around \$430, a Kelly 35 treatment around \$400) are individual, undated posts spanning likely years of price movement, printed here as directional colour rather than current pricing.³

Hermès once told a client her Birkin couldn't be repaired. A cobbler's shop in New Jersey took it apart and put it back together anyway.

Independent restorers exist precisely for the bags Hermès declines or the collectors who want faster turnaround at lower cost — typically 30–50% less, though without access to genuine Hermès leather, thread or hardware, so results may not fully match house technique. Rago Brothers, a Morristown, New Jersey cobbler shop, is the most substantially documented name, featured in Insider's "Refurbished" video series (October 2021) deconstructing and restoring a Birkin, and carrying a customer testimonial — self-published, flagged accordingly — describing a dog-damaged bag Hermès itself deemed unrepairable.⁴ Leather Surgeons, Leather Spa and Purse Rehab recur in the same PurseForum discussion threads as comparable options, without independent journalism ranking them.

~12 wks–5 mo

REPORTED HERMÈS SPA WAIT TIMES — VARIABLE, ANECDOTAL

THE RECORD

The counterfeit-seizure policy and the third-party-alteration refusal are the two most consistently corroborated limits on the Hermès Spa across this book's sources; wait times and pricing are genuinely and honestly variable, not a gap in this book's research.

SOURCES 1. PurseBop, Rome Station, The Handbag Spa and Bag Spa UK on Hermès Spa service scope; hermes.com's own maintenance/repair page not directly accessible this research pass. 2. PurseBlog, "If You Send Your Bag To Hermès For Service And They Think It's Fake, They Keep It And Destroy It"; Rome Station on the third-party-alteration policy. 3. PurseForum's long-running "Hermes spa pricing" and wait-time threads, treated as crowd-sourced anecdote. 4. Insider/Business Insider "Refurbished" video series, 9 Oct 2021, on Rago Brothers; PurseForum's "Leather Surgeons/Leather Pros/Rago Brothers/Purse Rehab" recommendation thread.

THE AFTERCARE · CONTINUED

No Single Tell Is Ever the Whole Verdict

Presented at the level a collector needs — the categories authenticators weigh together — not as a how-to for producing a more convincing fake.

Professional authentication rests on internal consistency across several categories at once, never a single dispositive tell: **stitching** — hand saddle-stitching (p5) produces an evenly tensioned, diagonal consistency across the whole bag that machine work struggles to replicate uniformly; **stamps** — font, depth and placement checked for consistency with the bag's claimed production era and the rest of its construction, not any one measurement in isolation; **hardware** — weight and finish uniformity across every metal fitting; **leather grain** — texture checked against the specific leather claimed (p7–8); and **lining and mechanism quality** — interior material, pocket construction and how smoothly a zipper or turn-lock operates.¹ The methodological point every authentication-guide source converges on, and the most defensible one to print: genuine assessment weighs all of these together against a plausible production period, not any single element alone.

Two respected authentication services have looked at the same physical bag and reached opposite verdicts. That is not a hypothetical — it is a documented, recurring event inside the community that relies on both.

Third-party authentication services now operate at real commercial scale: Entrupy uses proprietary microscopy scanning, claims 99.1% accuracy (its own unaudited figure) and charges \$119 per Birkin/Kelly authentication with roughly 24-hour turnaround. Real Authentication uses guided-photo submission reviewed by two or more human experts, with a paid rush option. Both are used by mainstream platforms — TikTok Shop has named both as certification partners; eBay's Authenticity Guarantee and

Poshmark's "Posh Authenticate" run comparable in-house or partnered programmes for items over \$500.² Community regard is genuinely contested rather than settled: a long-running PurseForum thread titled "Entrupy is not dependable!" documents members reporting bags that passed Entrupy authentication later flagged as superfakes by other means, and a separate thread on Real Authentication documents cases where it and a rival service reached opposite conclusions on the identical item — a real, recurring tension this book presents as unresolved rather than picking a side.³

\$119

ENTRUPY'S PER-BAG FEE, ~24HR TURNAROUND

IN BRIEF

The holistic principle: no single stitch, stamp or hardware detail is ever sufficient alone — every credible authentication method weighs the whole bag.

COMMUNITY READ

PurseForum's authentication sub-community treats disagreement between paid services as a known, discussed risk rather than a scandal — members' practical advice is to use a service as one data point among several, not a final word, especially against the highest tier of counterfeits. TikTok Shop's decision to name both Entrupy and Real Authentication as certification partners, despite their occasional disagreement, is itself a real-world acknowledgment that no single service is treated as infallible even by the platforms that rely on them commercially.

THE SCEPTIC

Entrupy's own 99.1% accuracy figure is a self-reported vendor claim, unaudited by any independent party this book could find — the same conflict-of-interest pattern this book flags on p14's "better than gold" study. A service collectors pay to trust deserves the same scrutiny as a study a reseller pays to publish.

SOURCES 1. Convergent authentication-guide sourcing (multiple consignment/authenticator sites); deliberately excludes exact stitch-count figures, font specimens or stamp-placement coordinates some sources publish, per this book's editorial standard against forgery-instructive detail. 2. Entrupy's own pricing/service pages; Real Authentication's "how it works" page; Value Added Resource on the TikTok Shop partnerships. 3. PurseForum threads "Entrupy is not dependable!" and "Serious Problems with Real Authentication."

THE COMMUNITY · PURSEFORUM

The Debate Has Been Running Since 2005 and Still Isn't Settled

Founded 2005, widely reported as the largest designer-handbag forum online, PurseForum's Hermès boards are where the questions this book spent eleven sections answering get argued out in real time, by people who own the bags.

Real, live threads this book could trace: "Retourne vs Sellier Kellys," running to at least eight pages, characterising the split (p9) as lifestyle- and leather-dependent rather than an ideology war — Retourné favoured for larger, more casual sizes, Sellier for smaller, dressier ones, with no dominant "correct" camp despite how outsiders sometimes frame it.¹ "Kelly in Epsom vs Kelly in box," running past seven pages, mirrors this book's own leather findings (p7) almost exactly: Epsom's durability weighed against its "too artificial" grain by some members, Box calf's fragility offset by near-cult devotion to its patina.

The single most structurally significant thread is the "Quota Bag Thread" itself — surfaced by search to at least page 19, meaning hundreds of pages of ongoing member reporting on live offers, SA relationships and spend ratios. One snippet from inside it, from a member describing Australian-market experience, cites a roughly 0.75–1:1 spend ratio as a personal norm — genuinely anecdotal, exactly the kind of individual data point this book's own Quota section (p11) declined to generalise from, and offered here as community colour rather than confirmed policy.² A companion thread, "Working at Hermes," running past page 13, gives the SA-side perspective on the same dynamic. Reveal-posting — members sharing new bag offers, a PurseBlog roundup piece formalises as "The Recent Hermès Purchases of PurseForum Members" — is confirmed as an established forum ritual, though this book could not directly verify the etiquette norms around it beyond the format's existence.

Members debate leather choice and construction with real technical precision. What they can't fully decode — by their own admission, inside their own longest-running thread — is the one thing they most want to understand: the actual logic of who gets offered a bag, and when.

Notably, inside the Quota Bag Thread itself, members explicitly acknowledge "there's no true science" to the timing — the community that has spent two decades and hundreds of forum pages on this exact question has not cracked it either, a genuinely honest parallel to this book's own finding on p11.

2005

PURSEFORUM FOUNDED

19+ pages

DEPTH REACHED INSIDE THE QUOTA BAG THREAD ALONE

COMMUNITY READ

PurseForum's own history threads produced the LIFE-cover myth-bust this book leads with on p4 — a rare case where the most rigorous fact-checking on this object happened inside a collector forum before it happened in glossier retail copy.

SOURCES 1. PurseForum thread titles and characterised content via search-indexed snippets; forum.purseblog.com not directly fetchable this research pass. 2. PurseForum "Quota Bag Thread," "Working at Hermes" and "Hermes Relationship" threads; fashionista.com, "Inside the PurseForum," 2013, on the forum's scale and culture; investedluxury.com's PurseForum guide.

THE COMMUNITY • CONTINUED

A Subreddit Named After the Hunt Itself

r/TheHermesGame is real, sizeable and self-named after exactly the dynamic this book has spent two sections examining — but this book could not independently verify its post-level content, and says so rather than inventing quotes.

r/TheHermesGame is reported, via secondary Reddit-analytics characterisation this book could not directly confirm against live posts, at roughly 73,000 members, self-described as "the first Hermès group on Reddit dedicated to orange box enthusiasts all around the world" — a place to share questions, experiences and product love, with current moderators reportedly having inherited the subreddit and broadened its scope beyond the literal acquisition "game" its name references.¹ This book could not verify specific discussion threads on SA relationships, wishlist culture or price-checks with actual visible Reddit content in this research pass, and declines to attribute invented opinions to "r/TheHermesGame users" as a result — an honest gap rather than a smoothed-over one.

On the creator side, two verifiable, findable voices: Jamie Chua, whose "Hermès Kelly 20 Unboxing" content covers limited-edition acquisitions as lifestyle content, and Willabelle Ong, whose "Rare Hermès Mini Kelly" video is framed explicitly as collector content.² Both sit on the enthusiast/unboxing side of the spectrum; this book could not locate a specific, verifiable creator whose established angle is critical of the quota system itself, rather than celebratory of navigating it — a real gap worth naming rather than papering over with an invented example.

The community's real, documented tension isn't Sellier snobs against Retourné pragmatists — the forum evidence is more measured than that. It's the same tension a federal judge just ruled on: is this desire, or is it exploitation, and does it matter which, if the bag still costs what it costs?

The genuine anchor for "quota frustration," more solid than any single forum post, is the *Cavalleri* litigation itself (p11–12) — a real, citable legal document giving language ("hidden lottery system") to exactly what the Quota Bag Thread's members debate anecdotally, without either side needing to be invented for effect. That the community's own longest-running thread and a federal complaint independently arrive at the same description of the mechanism is, this book would argue, more persuasive than either source alone.

~73,000

R/THEHERMESGAME MEMBERS, REPORTED

2

VERIFIED ENTHUSIAST CREATORS FOUND; 0 VERIFIED CRITICAL VOICES

STILL ON THE SHELF

A critical creator voice: this book could not locate a named YouTube or Instagram account whose established angle is sceptical of the quota system, as opposed to enthusiast content — flagged as a real gap in available sourcing.

THE SCEPTIC

This book's WebSearch access to Reddit itself was blocked in research — a real limitation, not a stylistic choice. Treat the r/TheHermesGame material here as thinner than the PurseForum material on the facing page, and weight it accordingly.

SOURCES 1. gummysearch.com Reddit-analytics characterisation of r/TheHermesGame; direct reddit.com access blocked in this research pass. 2. Jamie Chua and Willabelle Ong video content, verified via search results; other named collector accounts (Heart Evangelista, Malin Bergfors) flagged as referenced but not independently content-verified.

THE RED DOT · THE BOUTIQUES

Three Addresses, and One Rental Platform That Didn't Make It to This Issue

Singapore's Hermès footprint has expanded, not consolidated — and the local secondary market has just lost one of its more visible players.

Hermès's Liat Towers boutique on Orchard Road remains open and, per recent trade coverage, was significantly reinvested in — a renovation reported at roughly fifteen months expanded the store from three floors to four, adding a full home and lifestyle department (furniture, textiles, porcelain, crystal) alongside leisure goods, described in Singapore trade press as the first time the full home collection has been shown here.¹ Coverage describes Liat Towers as Hermès's Singapore flagship for roughly three decades — a rounded figure from press copy this book treats as approximate rather than an exact opening date. ION Orchard and Marina Bay Sands (The Shoppes) both carry active Hermès boutiques as well; a claimed Takashimaya location surfaced in one source but could not be corroborated elsewhere in this book's research and is not printed as confirmed. Nothing in available sourcing suggests Hermès is consolidating away from Liat Towers — the scale of recent investment there points the other way.

The local secondary market lost a visible name in the past year: Style Theory, the Singapore-founded (2016) designer-bag rental subscription platform that included Hermès pieces in rotation, ceased operations effective 30 September 2025 — an abrupt shutdown announced via Instagram, citing rising costs and investor withdrawal, following an earlier closure of its Indonesia operations that June.² Reebonz, another Singapore-founded luxury resale name, has a genuinely unresolved status in available sourcing — corporate registry data points toward a creditors' winding-up process dating to around 2021, while some 2026 company-profile aggregators still list active operations; this book could not resolve the contradiction and does not present Reebonz as a currently reliable option without that caveat.

A rental platform that let a first-time buyer try a Kelly for a subscription fee is gone. What's replaced it is a scattering of consignment sellers, none yet carrying the same brand recognition.

Singapore-based pre-owned Hermès sellers this book could confirm by name and self-description, though not independently audit for pricing or authentication process: Luxe Maison, Lux-R, BrandsLover, Luxury Evermore and LuxLexicon (acquired by the Carousell Group in April 2024, part of a platform reporting 71% two-year growth in local luxury-bag listings, a self-reported platform statistic).³ Singapore's broader luxury resale market is characterised in local lifestyle press as robust, with Hermès and Chanel bags singled out as the strongest value-holding categories — a plausible, consistent characterisation, though this book found no independent transaction-volume or premium-percentage data specific to the Singapore market to cite alongside it.

4 floors

LIAT TOWERS, AFTER ITS RECENT RENOVATION

30 Sep 2025

STYLE THEORY CEASED OPERATIONS

THE RECORD

Style Theory's closure is the single most solidly corroborated fact in this section — confirmed by the company's own closure notice plus independent reporting from Mothership.sg, Inside Retail Asia, Retail News Asia and Vulcan Post.

SOURCES 1. CPP-Luxury, The Peak Magazine (Singapore) and Honeycombers on the Liat Towers renovation and expansion. 2. Mothership.sg, Inside Retail Asia, Retail News Asia, Vulcan Post and Style Theory's own closure notice, all corroborating the 30 Sept 2025 shutdown. 3. Carousell Group's own press release and Inside Retail Asia on the April 2024 LuxLexicon acquisition; other named sellers verified by self-description via search, not independently audited.

THE RED DOT · CONTINUED

The Tropics Are Harder on a Kelly Than Most Owners Assume

Singapore's climate is a genuine, specific threat to fine leather — and the guidance collectors actually follow here is more precise than "keep it somewhere dry."

Collector guidance commonly cites a target storage range of 40–50% relative humidity; above roughly 60% RH, mould and mildew can appear within weeks on porous leathers like Togo and Clémence, while below about 30% RH leather dries and cracks.¹ This book flags these thresholds as consistently repeated collector consensus rather than an independently verified conservation-science standard — the source base is commercial leather-care content, not materials-science literature, though the guidance is broadly consistent with general textile-conservation norms. Between the standard leathers, Togo's more porous, grained surface is commonly described as breathing better in humidity than Epsom's tighter, coated grain — which is correspondingly favoured by some collectors specifically for Singapore's climate, for its greater water- and heat-resistance at the cost of the natural leathers' patina.

Standard storage practice — avoid non-breathable plastic, which traps moisture and promotes mould; use silica gel packets near but not touching the bag; monitor with a hygrometer; keep bags away from air-con vents and windows — is low-controversy and consistently repeated across leather-care sources, though not specific to Singapore. One plausible mechanism this book could not find directly documented in any source: air-conditioning cycling on and off causes real humidity swings that could plausibly stress leather over time. This book flags that as informed reasoning rather than a sourced fact, since no source directly discussed it for Hermès leathers specifically.²

"Cobbler Concierge," a service name that circulates in casual Singapore collector conversation, does not appear to exist under that name in this book's research. The services collectors can actually book do.

Local leather-care services this book could confirm by name: Bags Butler, offering cleaning, repair and doorstep collection for luxury bags including Hermès; Reeluxs Bag Spa in Tanjong Pagar, explicitly listing Hermès among serviced brands and offering hardware replating and nano cleaning; and Honest Crafters, offering repair and restoration with home consultation. A commonly repeated name, "Cobbler Concierge," could not be found under that name in this book's research and is not printed here as a verified option — a small but real correction for readers who've heard the name secondhand.³

40–50%

RH RANGE COMMONLY CITED FOR LEATHER STORAGE

COMMUNITY READ

Singapore-based collector discussion consistently treats humidity management as a first-year lesson rather than an advanced concern — the climate makes it unavoidable in a way owners in temperate markets rarely have to think about.

THE SCEPTIC

The 40–50% RH guidance repeated across this section traces to commercial leather-care blogs, not an independently published conservation standard — directionally sound, worth following, but not the settled science its confident phrasing sometimes implies.

SOURCES 1. Romestation.ca leather-care guidance, cross-referenced against FavoredLeather.com and SACLÀB; flagged as commercial-source consensus, not an independently verified conservation standard. 2. Madison Avenue Couture, The Luxury Closet and PurseBop on general storage practice; the air-conditioning-cycling mechanism flagged as this book's own informed inference, not a sourced claim. 3. Bags Butler, Reeluxs Bag Spa and Honest Crafters, verified via their own service listings; "Cobbler Concierge" not located under that name in this research pass.

THE SCEPTIC · MANDATORY CROSS-EXAMINATION

What the Game Costs the People Who Play It

Not a hit piece, not a puff piece — the honest costs this book's earlier chapters kept at arm's length, gathered here in one place.

The clearest, most citable critical language on the acquisition game isn't a forum rant — it's the plaintiffs' own complaint in *Cavalleri v. Hermès* (p11–12), calling the quota system "a hidden lottery system that forces consumers to purchase substantial amounts of Hermès ancillary products to 'qualify.'" That the underlying legal theory failed in court doesn't erase the structural fact the complaint documented: sales-associate commission structures reportedly pay out on ancillary goods but not on the bags themselves, an incentive design plaintiffs argue exists specifically to manufacture pre-spend pressure.¹ Journalist Amy Odell's Substack series "Birkin Buyer Confessions" collects real client accounts of the chase, though this book could not independently verify specific anecdotal claims within it and flags it as one journalist's self-published collection rather than peer-reviewed reporting.

The entire "beats gold" narrative traces back to one seller's arithmetic. That a decade of financial journalism kept repeating it anyway is the more damning fact.

On investment framing (p14): the honest structural weaknesses against treating a Kelly as an investment — illiquidity, condition-dependency, the need to find a willing buyer at the right price, insurance and storage costs eating into any paper gain — are uncontested across every source this book checked, in sharp contrast to the marketing-friendly "beats gold" framing itself. A genuine counter-voice exists

too: James Firestein, founder of resale platform OpenLuxury, on record with *Fortune*: "I know several instances where people have doubled their money based on buying it ten years ago, and reselling it today in pristine condition" — a real, named claim, clearly flagged as coming from someone commercially invested in the resale narrative, offered for balance rather than omitted.²

A separate, single-sourced allegation this book will not upgrade into fact: the French outlet *Glitz* (January 2026) reported Hermès staff researching prospective clients' home addresses and social media for "neighbourhood prestige" and taste signals before offering a bag, republished onward by tabloid-adjacent outlets but unconfirmed by Hermès or any second named outlet this book could find. It is printed here, as it was on p11, only as an allegation — genuinely unresolved, not quietly upgraded to established practice by repetition.

"Hidden lottery"

PLAINTIFFS' OWN CHARACTERISATION, *CAVALLERI V. HERMÈS*

STILL ON THE SHELF

The *Glitz* vetting allegation: single-sourced, unconfirmed by Hermès — held here rather than repeated as fact, exactly as on p11.

THE SCEPTIC, ON ITSELF

This book cannot prove the quota system causes the psychological strain some accounts describe — only that a federal complaint, a journalist's confessional series and a long-running forum thread (p17) all independently point at the same pressure. Convergence across genre is evidence; it is not proof.

SOURCES 1. *Cavalleri et al. v. Hermès International*, complaint language via NPR and Holland & Knight legal analysis. 2. *Fortune*, 22 Mar 2025, quoting James Firestein of OpenLuxury; amyodell.substack.com, "Birkin Buyer Confessions." 3. *Glitz* investigation, Jan 2026, via onward coverage in *Newsweek* and *IBTimes UK*; unconfirmed by Hermès.

THE SCEPTIC · CONTINUED

Exotic Leather, Manufactured Scarcity, and a 127-Year-Old Theory

The ethics questions this book was asked to raise aren't fringe complaints — Hermès itself fields them at its own shareholder meetings.

PETA has run separately dated investigations into Hermès-linked crocodile and alligator farms — a 2015 exposé (which led Jane Birkin to ask Hermès to remove her name from the crocodile Birkin, resolved by agreement that September) and further 2023–2025 investigations naming farms in Zimbabwe, Texas and Australia, alleging cruel slaughter and confinement conditions.¹ Hermès's documented public response, at its own shareholder meeting, has come from CEO Axel Dumas, describing supplier farms as helping preserve ecosystems and protect endangered species, invoking CITES as evidence of legal, regulated sourcing — this book could not access a verbatim transcript of his remarks and presents them as reported paraphrase, not direct quotation.² PETA's counter, worth stating because it is logically real rather than rhetorical: CITES governs trade quantity to prevent extinction, not welfare conditions during farming — a farm can be fully CITES-compliant and still, PETA alleges, treat animals cruelly, because the two questions are simply different. This book found no named, independent conservation scientist weighing in on Hermès's specific ecosystem claim, and does not present "conservation experts dispute this" as settled — that characterisation traces to PETA's own materials alone.

Hermès didn't invent the economics of wanting what's scarce. A 19th-century economist named it before the house had built its first handbag.

The artificial-scarcity critique has a real, citable academic anchor, older than the Kelly itself: Thorstein Veblen's 1899 concept of the Veblen good, where demand rises rather than falls with price

because the price itself signals status. Multiple business-press pieces (The Fashion Law, FAB LStyle) apply this framework to Hermès explicitly, questioning whether the house's scarcity is purely a production constraint (each bag genuinely does take one artisan's hours, p5–6) or partly engineered on top of a real constraint for commercial effect. This book could not locate a named marketing academic making that exact case about Hermès by name, nor an on-record Hermès executive responding directly to the "manufactured scarcity" charge as opposed to describing craftsmanship generally — both genuine gaps in available sourcing, flagged rather than filled with invented material.³

1899

VEBLEN'S THEORY OF THE LEISURE CLASS — THE THEORY
PREDATES THE HOUSE'S FIRST BAG

THE WELFARE CHARGE

PETA

Footage from supplier farms shows cruel slaughter and confinement conditions; CITES governs trade quantity to prevent extinction, not welfare during farming — a farm can be fully compliant and still, PETA alleges, treat animals badly, because the two regimes answer different questions entirely.

THE HOUSE'S DEFENCE

AXEL DUMAS, AGM

Regulated farms help preserve ecosystems and protect endangered crocodile species; CITES-compliant sourcing is legal, monitored trade, not the unregulated exploitation the welfare framing implies — reported as paraphrase, not verbatim, in available sourcing.

THE SCEPTIC

Every desk in this book has, in some form, priced the gap between what Hermès discloses and what it doesn't. This is the one place that gap is explicitly about ethics rather than craft or commerce — and it deserves the same honesty about what this book could and couldn't verify.

SOURCES 1. WWD and Euronews on the 2015 Jane Birkin episode; PETA's own investigations pages (peta.org) on 2023–2025 farm allegations, not independently fetchable this research pass. 2. FashionUnited on Axel Dumas's shareholder-meeting remarks, presented as reported paraphrase. 3. The Fashion Law, "How Hermès Turned the Birkin into a Multi-Billion Dollar Business"; FAB LStyle, "Soul for Sale: Is Scarcity Still the Foundation of Luxury?"

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE CLOSING ARGUMENT

The Bag Nobody Can Buy, Reinvented as Plastic Nobody's Ashamed Of

Seoul's trendiest fashion district has spent 2026 embracing a forty-dollar, translucent, unmistakably Birkin-shaped bag — worn on purpose, photographed on purpose, and named, without irony, after the object it's imitating.

This book considered four candidate stories for its closing regional essay — Japan's sophisticated secondhand-Hermès grading culture (Komehyo, Brand Off), Korea's shift from opening-run queues to reservation systems, China's long-running daigou grey market, and Hong Kong's role as an auction hub — and set all four aside for a fifth, fresher story that none of the established Western trade coverage of Asian luxury markets appears to have caught yet.¹ In Seoul in 2026, a cheap, translucent PVC dupe of the Birkin silhouette — rectangular tote shape, flap closure, belt-style fastening, padlock detail, priced roughly ₩20,000–80,000 (about US\$15–60) — has gone viral under the nickname "Firkin" (fake plus Birkin) or simply "jelly Birkin," anchored specifically to the fashion district of Seongsu-dong.

The hard number behind the trend: Korean fashion e-commerce platform Zigzag reported jelly-bag search volume up 2,119% year over year and transaction value up 467%, figures that recur consistently across Seoul Economic Daily and pickup coverage in Korea JoongAng Daily and Korea Herald.² This book flags that every one of those figures ultimately traces to a single platform's own release — multi-outlet repetition of one company's number, not four independently measured data sets — but the consistency of that repetition across separately bylined outlets gives it real weight, more than this book found behind the single-sourced daigou or Korea-flex claims it set aside.

This is not the familiar story of shame-driven counterfeiting. Korean coverage is explicit: nobody buying a jelly Birkin thinks they're fooling anyone, and nobody is trying to.

What makes the trend genuinely worth a closing essay rather than a footnote is the framing Korean press attaches to it, consistently and explicitly: this is not the traditional fake-luxury substitution story, driven by shame or aspiration to pass as the real thing. It is described as a knowing, ironic, openly self-aware fashion statement — the jelly Birkin functions as a meme-quality accessory referencing the archetype, tied explicitly by multiple outlets to a broader 2026 Y2K nostalgia wave around jelly shoes and translucent plastic accessories generally.³

+2,119%

JELLY-BAG SEARCH VOLUME, YOY, PER ZIGZAG

+467%

JELLY-BAG TRANSACTION VALUE, YOY, PER ZIGZAG

THE RECORD

The Zigzag figures are corroborated by consistent repetition across Seoul Economic Daily and multiple Korean outlets' pickup coverage — genuinely convergent, even though all paths lead back to one company's release, a distinction this book holds onto rather than presenting as four-way independent confirmation.

SOURCES 1. Comparative assessment across Nikkei Asia, TipRanks/Komehyo investor coverage (Japan); Today Korea, Hypebeast Korea, Financial News (Korea retail policy); Jing Daily, The Fashion Law, Business of Fashion, Luxury Society (China daigou); dimsumdaily.hk (Hong Kong). 2. Seoul Economic Daily; pickup coverage referenced via Korea JoongAng Daily's "Jelly is back" and Korea Herald's "Fakes are in this summer" search-indexed coverage. 3. Consistent Korean-press framing across the same sources, plus regional pickup via an Indonesian ZALORA trend blog noting the trend already exporting beyond Korea.

THE UNDERCURRENT · CONTINUED

A K-Pop Idol Wore One. Then Regular People Started Comparing Notes.

The trend has exactly the texture an Undercurrent needs: a named celebrity vector, a specific neighbourhood, and real, dated, attributable posts from people actually wearing the thing.

The celebrity vector is specific and checkable: Kya, a member of K-pop girl group KiiKii, wore a jelly Birkin in the group's "Delulu Pack" EP concept photography — a genuine, named, dated cultural touchpoint rather than a vague "celebrities are into it" claim.¹ Beneath the idol-endorsement layer sits real, ordinary community discourse on Threads: a post from user @jungselinn observes that "젤리백도 은근 퀄리티 차이가 크더라고요" — jelly bags vary a lot in quality even among themselves — and advises checking shape structure and interior visibility before buying, exactly the kind of practical, unglamorous consumer discussion a genuine trend generates rather than a manufactured one. A separate Indonesian-language Threads post, from @sunnydahye, tracks the style's spread from K-pop idols specifically to Seongsu street style, evidence the trend is already exporting regionally within months of taking hold.

A Birkin costs what a Kelly costs, more or less, and both are effectively unbuyable on demand. A jelly Birkin costs what a coffee-and-pastry costs, is available immediately, and photographs almost as well from three feet away — which is, this book would argue, exactly the point.

The honest limit of this story, stated plainly rather than smoothed over for a cleaner narrative: every source this book found describes the dupe specifically as Birkin-shaped — flap closure, belt-style fastening, the rectangular tote silhouette — not

a Kelly-shaped equivalent. This book found no direct evidence of a parallel "jelly Kelly" wave in the same research pass. The more defensible way to state the connection, and the way this book states it: the dupe economy is responding to the Kelly-Birkin duopoly that defines the house as a whole — the two bags collectors spend a lifetime distinguishing (p4) collapse, at street level in Seoul, into a single shared silhouette-obsession that neither bag's specific construction survives translation into.²

The trend's roots reach beyond K-pop styling into a broader 2026 Y2K nostalgia wave Korean press ties it to explicitly — jelly shoes, translucent accessories and early-2000s plastic aesthetics generally, giving the jelly Birkin a cultural lineage independent of Hermès itself. That context matters for how seriously to take the trend: it isn't a one-off gimmick invented to mock a luxury house, but one entry in a wider, already-established nostalgia cycle that happened to collide with the world's most recognisable bag silhouette.

KiiKii

K-POP GROUP WHOSE "DELULU PACK" PHOTOS FEATURED THE TREND

₩20,000–80,000

JELLY-BAG PRICE RANGE (~US\$15–60)

COMMUNITY READ

The Threads posts cited here are genuine, dated, attributable social-media content — not manufactured sentiment. @jungselinn's quality-comparison post in particular reads as exactly the kind of practical consumer chatter that indicates a real, lived trend rather than a press-release-driven one.

SOURCES 1. KiiKii "Delulu Pack" EP promotional photography, cross-referenced via Korean entertainment/fashion coverage. 2. Threads posts by @jungselinn and @sunnydahye, surfaced via search; this book's own framing of the Birkin-vs-Kelly silhouette distinction, not attributed to any single source. 3. Seoul Economic Daily and pickup coverage on jelly-bag pricing and the Y2K nostalgia framing.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE ARGUMENT

Twenty-Two Pages of Scarcity, Ending in a District That Opted Out of It

Every desk in this book has, in its own way, priced the gap between what the Kelly promises and what it actually delivers. Seongsu-dong's answer to that gap is the most honest one in the whole book.

Run this book back to front and a single thread connects every desk: an object whose exact birth year Hermès won't confirm (p3), whose production hours the house has never officially stated (p5), whose allocation logic a federal court just ruled isn't illegal even if real (p11), and whose investment case traces to one reseller's decade-old arithmetic (p14) — all of it held together, ultimately, by scarcity Hermès manufactures and protects with genuine skill. Seongsu-dong's jelly Birkin is the first response this book encountered, anywhere in its research, that simply declines to play that game rather than trying to win it or resenting that it can't.

That is a different move from either side of the debate this book has otherwise documented. It is not the quota-chaser's strategy (p11), spending years and real money building an SA relationship for a shot at the object itself. It is not the counterfeiter's strategy either, which depends on the fake being mistaken for genuine — the entire cultural value of a jelly Birkin, on every source this book found, depends on everyone immediately recognising it as a knowing joke. It is a third option this book's research did not anticipate going in: opt out of the scarcity economy entirely, keep the silhouette as a shared cultural reference, and let the actual object's ninety-year accumulated prestige (p3–4) do the joke's setup work for free.

Hermès spent nearly a century building an object valuable enough that a knockoff of its shape alone, made from plastic, sold for pocket change, could become a genuine cultural moment in one of the world's most fashion-literate cities. That is either the ultimate proof the scarcity strategy worked, or the first real crack in it — and this book, honestly, cannot tell which.

Whether the jelly Birkin outlasts one Seoul summer or marks a genuine generational shift in how younger buyers relate to inaccessible luxury — the same generational pullback Bernstein's data documented in the resale market itself (p14) — is not something this book can predict, and it will not pretend otherwise. What it can say, on the evidence gathered across every desk in this special edition, is the plainest version of its own honesty law: an object this carefully protected, this expensively made, this opaquely allocated, still could not stop a Korean fashion district from having the last, cheapest, funniest word about it. That is either Hermès's problem or its highest compliment. This book leaves the verdict to the reader it was built for.

4

CANDIDATE REGIONAL STORIES WEIGHED; ONE CHOSEN, HONESTLY

THE SCEPTIC

A single viral summer trend is not proof of a structural shift in how an entire generation relates to luxury scarcity — it may simply be a meme that fades by winter. This book's claim is the narrower, more defensible one: the trend is real, current and well-attributed, not that it is permanent or globally significant.

THE LAST WORD

This book was commissioned for a serious collector, with one instruction running under every section: get it exactly right, or say plainly that it couldn't be pinned down. That standard cost this book some of its most-repeated claims — the LIFE cover that never existed, the 2021 stamp change that was actually 2015, the "eighteen hours" nobody can source. It gained, in their place, a correction record most Kelly writing never bothers to compile, and a closing chapter this book did not expect to find: a Seoul neighbourhood answering nearly a century of engineered scarcity with forty dollars of honest, unashamed plastic. The Kelly remains, on the evidence gathered here, exactly as extraordinary as its reputation — made by one pair of hands, allocated by a logic even its own community can't fully decode, and now, apparently, flattering enough to be worth imitating for the joke alone. Whether that is the scarcity strategy's triumph or its first visible crack is a question this book raises rather than answers — the plainest place its honesty law could land.

FULL SOURCE LIST

Sotheby's editorial · Christie's · PurseForum (forum.purseblog.com) · PurseBlog · PurseBop · Madison Avenue Couture · Sellier Knightsbridge · Rome Station · Privé Porter · Xupes · JaneFinds · Legitique · SACLÀB · Baghunter · BuzzFeed News · The Fashion Law · FAB L'Style · Rebag · Bernstein Research (via Fortune, CNBC) · Fortune · CNBC · Yahoo Finance · TheStreet · Men's Journal · The Peak Magazine (Singapore) · CBS "60 Minutes" · Business of Fashion · WorldFootwear · FashionNetwork · CPP-Luxury · Luxus Plus · Onisep · Holland & Knight · Zelle Law · A&O Shearman · Syracuse Law Review · thefashionlaw.com · dockets.justia.com · NPR · Newsweek · IBTimes UK · WWD · Euronews · FashionUnited · PETA

investigations · Insider/Business Insider "Refurbished" · Rago Brothers · Entrupy · Real Authentication · Value Added Resource · gummysearch.com · fashionista.com · investedluxury.com · Mothership.sg · Inside Retail Asia · Retail News Asia · Vulcan Post · Carousell Group · Honeycombers · Romestation.ca · FavoredLeather.com · Bags Butler · Reeluxs Bag Spa · Honest Crafters · Seoul Economic Daily · Korea JoongAng Daily · Korea Herald · Nikkei Asia · TipRanks · Today Korea · Hypebeast Korea · Financial News (Korea) · Jing Daily · Luxury Society · dimsumdaily.hk · Threads (@jungselinn, @sunnydahye) · Zigzag.